

Assignment 4: Part II

Library Automation: RFP Document & Implementation Plan

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Request for Proposals

1. Introduction

The Seattle Public Library (SPL) [spl.org] was established in 1890 and is a department of the City of Seattle. SPL has maintained a reciprocal borrowing agreement with the King County Library System (KCLS) since 1943, and provides reciprocal services to 7 other nearby library systems as well. The population of the City of Seattle is over 755,000 people and the population of King County is over 2.3 million people. However, the libraries that serve the greater Seattle Metropolitan area represent over 4 million residents. On average, the Central Library hosts over 1.2 million visitors annually and the library branches serve over 3.6 million annual visitors. Over 32,000 people attended programs at SPL's Central Library in 2024. SPL loaned over 5.88 million books and other physical materials in the same period. The King County Library System (KCLS), which partners with SPL's central location, reported a record-breaking number of digital book loans in 2024. Over 10 million digital materials were loaned to patrons last year (Becker, 2011; Seattle Public Library, n.d.-c).

In addition to a 12 story, 363,000 square foot Central Library, SPL has a network of 26 other library locations throughout the Seattle Metropolitan area. However, there are over 50 libraries associated with KCLS and the other library systems consorting with SPL. The overarching priorities at SPL are equity and intellectual freedom. A wide array of adult and youth services are offered including books and media; research and reference; workshops and classes; job and career services; literacy and language services; computer and technology access; community and cultural programs; storytimes; homework help; summer reading programs; teen programs and events; youth literacy programs; creative arts and STEAM programs; and youth access to digital resources. In-depth information about all that SPL has to offer can be found at spl.org (*Reciprocal Agreements*, n.d.; Seattle Public Library, n.d.-c).

SPL is seeking competitive proposals from qualified vendors to provide and support a next-generation Integrated Library System (ILS) for bibliographic, data processing, cataloging, acquisitions, serials control, inventory functions, and interoperability with third-party vendors to accomplish a wide variety of library functions and management tasks. The Washington State Office of Financial Management expects to see a 4.6% increase in the population of King County residents from 2025 to 2030 (*Population*, n.d.). Given this projected growth, SPL and its partners expect to see a similar increase in the number of active library card holders) in the same timeframe. This significant increase will require next generation technologies that support the continued growth of SPL and its patron's interests and needs.

2. Background

SPL began automating in 1986, migrated from the Data Research Associates (DRA) system to Dynix in 1991, and from Dynix to Horizon in 2004. SPL added BiblioCommons' BiblioCore discovery layer in 2010. A new ILS that extends or replaces SPL's current utilization of Horizon and is interoperable with software/databases from third party vendors is being sought in consideration of the needs of SPL employees and the library's large, modern patron base. An updated and comprehensive user interface with feature-rich, advanced technologies and client-server architecture optimization is desired and would alleviate the challenges and issues librarians and patrons at SPL have recently faced. These challenges include security vulnerabilities (prominent cybersecurity/ransomware attack in May of 2024), performance decline, compatibility and compliance issues, data loss, hindered employee productivity, and workflow disruptions(*Seattle Public Library*, 2024).

As a large public library located in a major city within its state, SPL regularly relies on automation tasks in its operation. SPL currently employs a variety of systems to achieve such tasks as circulation,

digital content management, offering discovery tools to inquiring patrons, and the automatic sorting of materials. Current systems read as follows (*Seattle Public Library*, n.d.):

- Current ILS: Horizon (since 2004)
 - Former ILS: Dynix
- Discovery Interface: BiblioCore (since 2010)
- Digital Collection Management: CONTENTdm
- Web Content Management: Ingeniux
- Item ID: RFID
- Automated Materials Handling: Tech Logic
- Self-Service Checkout Kiosk System: Liber8

Public-facing technologies are also available and may aid patrons in job-seeking, catalog searching, and general productivity (*Seattle Public Library*, n.d.). Certain technologies, including computers and digital setups for meetings rooms have faced reduced priority in the library's budget (*Seattle Public Library*, n.d.). Publicly available technology includes the following (*Computers & Equipment*, n.d.):

- Desktop computers
 - Catalog (unlimited use)
 - Express (30 minutes)
 - Job seeking (2 hours)
- Printer
- Copy machine
- ScanEZ kiosks
- Wireless internet access
 - Circulating Wi-Fi hot spots

- Circulating laptops
- Graphing calculators
- Adaptive equipment
- Video conference meeting rooms

Finally, the library also operates self-service checkout kiosks by the company Biblioteka which are used to perform circulation tasks at all branches within the SPL system.

To successfully extend or replace Horizon, there are several objectives that must be considered including:

- Migration of ILS data off SPL's local servers
- Movement to a fully web-based, well-supported solution
- A shift to SaaS (Software as a Service) model
- Replacement for or integration with the BiblioCore discovery platform
- Requirement to follow current cybersecurity best practices

SPL, KCLS, and the 7 other nearby library systems with reciprocal borrowing services will benefit from the provision of around-the-clock service to patrons and staff, integrated support of current payment systems and other third-party products, and assistance with operational differences between consorting partners.

3. System Functionality Requirements

The library management system will need to be customized to meet SPL's unique operational, accessibility, and user engagement needs. The proposed system will undergo modifications to ensure seamless integration with existing infrastructure, compliance with library standards, and enhanced user experience for patrons and staff.

Instructions:

Fill out the System Functionality checklist. Each submission must include an electronic checklist of completed tasks. Select one of the five middle columns for each requirement and add comments as necessary.

Label	Label Meaning	Definition
A	Available	Vendor can meet this need.
O	Optional Addition	Vendor Supplies this need at an additional cost.
IT	In Testing	Vendor will be releasing this feature within 6 months from the due date of the RFP, and testing for this feature is well underway.
ID	In Development	Testing and release of this product is planned for at least two years from the due date of the RFP. Indicate the expected date and specification details.
NP	Not Planned	Not planned and not underdevelopment
	Comments	Additional comments from the vendor

	System Functionality Checklist	A	O	IT	ID	NP	Comments
1	General System Requirements						
1.1	Patron management tools including Registration, profile management, borrower classification, and linked family accounts.						
1.2	Check-in and checkout features with RFID and Barcode enable checkout, returns, and self-service kiosk integrations.						
1.3	Holds and reservations across multiple branches with hold prioritization and customizable hold limits.						
	System Functionality Checklist	A	O	IT	ID	NP	Comments
1.4	Fines and Fee management tools that calculate fines automatically, allow for online fine payments, and integrate with payment systems at SPL.						
1.5	Customizable Loan and renewal rules based on patron type and material format with autorenewals as an option.						
	Cataloging						
1.6	Meet metadata standards with MARC21, BIBFRAME, and RDA compliance for creation and enhancement.						
1.7	Automated authority files that update and link to data to support name and subject authorities.						
1.8	Batch processing with bulk imports and exports of records.						

1.9	Linked open data compatibility enables semantic web technology to improve resource discoverability.						
	Acquisitions						
1.10	Vendor integration for ordering and invoicing with book vendors.						
1.11	Accounting with real-time expense tracking and reporting.						
1.12	Fund accounting with budgeting tools and reporting tools.						
1.13	Alerts for missing orders.						
	Search and Discovery						
1.14	Discovery layer with a web interface, faceted search, and predictive search suggestions.						
1.15	Unified search with a federated search across all resources (Print, digital, and electronic).						
1.16	AI-powered recommendations, saved searches, and user-driven acquisition requests.						
1.17	Search compatibility with OCLC, WorldCat, JSTOR, and local university libraries.						
	Serials & Electronic Resource Management						
1.18	Serial check-in with automated subscription tracking.						
1.19	Seamlessly link to full-text e-resources via OpenURL standards.						
1.20	Storage of electronic resources licenses, renewal alerts, and tracking compliance.						
	Reporting and Analytics						
1.21	Reports on circulation, acquisitions, and User activity.						
1.22	Export capabilities of reports via CSV, Excel, and PDF						
1.23	Data visualization features with interactive charts and graphs for tracking trends, usage, and collections.						
	Administration and staff Workflows						
1.24	Staff member roles and permission allow for interchangeable access levels for staff, volunteers, and external partners						
1.25	Multi-branch management features that allow customizable policies per branch for lending rules and local collections.						
1.26	Automated email notifications for overdue items, purchase requests, and system updates.						
2	Integration Requirements						
2.1	Seamless Integrations with SPL existing ILS Horizon.						

2.2	Seamless Integrations with SPL current RFID self-checkout and book return system Liber8.						
2.3	Seamless Integrations with mobile app interface, both iOS and Android.						
2.4	Seamless Integrations with SPL Discovery platform BiblioCore.						
2.5	Seamless Integrations with E-resources platforms (Hoopla, Kanopy, Libby, Overdrive and Flipster).						
2.6	Seamless Integrations with SPL payment system.						
3	Security and Data Privacy Requirements						
3.1	User authentication and role-based access restrictions.						
3.2	Secure encryption for all data in transit.						
3.3	Compliance: General data protection regulations, Washington Privacy Act (WPA), and Washington Foundational Data Privacy Act (FDPA)for patron data protection.						
3.4	Audit Logs: Detailed tracking of system actions and transactions for compliance.						
3.5	Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA): For staff and administrator access.						
3.6	Detailed tracking of system actions and transactions. Alerting suspicious activity or users.						
3.7	Multi-Factor Authentication for staff and administrator access.						
4	Scalability Requirements						
4.1	Cloud-based hosting options.						
4.2	Support for future increase user traffic, circulation, and the expansion of digital resources.						
4.3	Seamless upgrades and potential feature expansion.						
4.4	AI capability: software can use AI search enhancements and automated metadata tagging.						
5	Technical Requirements						
5.1	Hardware Requirement: 8-core processors, 64GB RAM, and 1 TB SSD storage.						
5.2	Hardware Requirement: 1Gbps minimum LAN connectivity for the network infrastructure.						
5.3	Hardware Requirement: Database Server using PostgreSQL and MySQL.						
5.4	Software Requirement: SaaS model.						
5.5	Network Requirements: Cloud hosting options like AWS or Microsoft Azure.						
	Network Requirements: Minimum 1 Gbps for cloud access.						

4. Vendor Qualifications

SPL asks that qualified vendors submit proposals in response to this RFP. Vendors must show their ability to meet the requirements outlined in this section by providing detailed responses to the following qualifications:

1. Provide Background and History of your company. Qualifications must include:
 - 1.1. Company name, address, and contact information
 - 1.2. Company establishment year and history
 - 1.3. Legal Structure (meaning LLC, Corporation, or sole proprietorship)
 - 1.4. Mission statement and values
 - 1.5. Essential staff that will be involved in this project
2. Financial Health. This section must include audited financial statements from the past 3 years.
3. Experience with Similar Projects. Qualifications must include:
 - 3.1. A list of projects from the past 5 years with similar scopes.
 - 3.2. References from 3 current or former clients, including those of public libraries.
 - 3.3. Description of project challenges and how you overcame them.
4. What Customer support options do you offer? Please list this as well as the following:
 - 4.1. Customer support hours
 - 4.2. Response times
 - 4.3. Training programs provided for library staff.
 - 4.4. If you offer manuals, FAQs, or video instructions.

5. Budget & Pricing

Please provide a quote for unit pricing, maintenance rates, delivery and setup charges, installation and licensing fees, and training costs for all the components of the system on the summary form provided below. Please attach any supplemental information if need be. Please indicate the duration of any/all warranties and/or coverages for each component as well. The installation of all system components must be completed within six months after the contract is signed. Any variance or departure from this schedule must be indicated. All proposals must include a statement of validity for a minimum of 90 days from the date proposals close. Please add extra rows if there are insufficient rows to provide the information necessary to complete the proposal.

Pricing Form

Vendor Name: _____

Item	Unit Price	# Units	Total Price	Maintenance Price
ILS Database				
ILS Hosting				
ILS Software (breakdown per module if necessary)				
ILS OPAC (patron use), adjust if not applicable				
ILS Client Software (staff use)				
Reporting Software				
Testing Environment				
Functional				
Performance				
Security				
Customization Estimate				
Optional Modules and Services				
Self-Checkout				
Children's OPAC				
Website Hosting				
Print Management				
PC Reservation				
Room Reservation				
Events Calendar				
Delivery				
Installation				
Training				
Documentation				
Travel				
Per Diem				
Total System				

6. Evaluation Criteria

Vendors and ILS products will be evaluated and ranked according to the following criteria. Only vendors with complete RFP responses will be scored. The maximum number of points that may be awarded to one vendor totals 100.

Evaluation Criteria	Points
System Requirements: ILS satisfies system requirements as outlined under section “3. System Functionality Requirements”. ILS is expected to conform to existing SPL policies and will provide a smooth transition from current system.	40
Proposed Cost: System aligns with SPL budget and is itemized clearly under as required under section “5. Budget & Pricing”.	25
Vendor Qualifications: Vendor fulfills requirements as listed under section “4. Vendor Qualifications”. Vendor has also provided organizational reference chart outlining staffing needs, key personnel, and service providers as required for implementation of ILS. Personnel qualifications should also be given.	10
Maintenance: Vendor-provided plan for maintenance before, during, and following the implementation of the ILS fulfills technical support requirements as described. This plan must include whether any required training will be virtual or on-site. Plan must also offer an SaaS solution for technical support. Regular support may involve running reporting tasks, system configuration, and other general system operations.	8
Staff Preference: Allocation for staff preferences following review of completed RFP response, on-site demonstration, preferences for technical features or interfaces, and any additional vendor communications.	7
On-site Demonstration: Product demonstration is thorough, professional, and adequately addresses criteria as outlined above. SPL staff questions are answered clearly, and system administrators are given clear, direct walkthroughs of product features.	10

A maximum of three highly ranked, shortlisted vendors will each be required to perform an on-site demonstration in order to complete their bid. Demonstrations will consist of oral presentations of relevant ILS features accompanied by visual aids. Vendor representatives are expected to allow time for questions from library personnel following their demonstrations. Two SPL system administrators will be selected to receive further instruction and specialized, hands-on walkthroughs of ILS features from vendor representatives. Following each presentation, a score will be awarded by a selected committee of SPL library personnel and totaled with the criteria listed above.

Implementation Plan

7. Timeline

The timetable below reflects the predicted schedule for the Request for Proposal and contract negotiation process. The exact dates and sequences of events resulting from this Request for Proposal may vary and will ultimately be determined by SPL.

Event	Anticipated Date
Request for proposal issued	Wednesday, March 12, 2025
Last day for written questions	Friday, April 4, 2025
Request for proposal closes	Friday, April 11, 2025
Finalists on-site demos	4th week of May, 2025
Proposal evaluation completed	Friday, June 20, 2025
Negotiation of contract commences	Monday, July 7, 2025
Contract is signed	Friday, August 1, 2025
Acceptance	Within 6 months after signing contract

8. Staffing

A structured staffing plan has been developed to support the implementation of the new integrated library system, or ILS, at the Seattle Public Library, ensuring a smooth transition for staff and patrons. The plan is divided into three main phases: implementation, training, and ongoing support. During the implementation phase oversight will be provided by the project manager while a team of systems librarians will be responsible for configuring the new system, troubleshooting technical issues, and ensuring that all required integrations are properly in place. Data migration specialists will oversee the transfer and validation of records. This ensures that bibliographic and patron information will remain private and intact. A cryptosecurity analyst will also be assigned to monitor compliance with Washington state privacy regulations and to safeguard sensitive patron data. Vendor representatives will also be involved as providing technical expertise and addressing system specific concerns as they arise is a key part of this process.

As part of the training phase a 'train-the-trainer' model will be utilized. System administrators will receive initial training from the vendor, allowing them to gain a comprehensive understanding of the system's functionalities. These administrators will then train librarians and supervisors, who will further instruct paraprofessional staff on daily operations such as check-in and check-out procedures, patron account management and catalog navigation. To assist patrons, temporary user support personnel will be stationed at key locations to answer questions and troubleshoot potential issues. Following the go-live date, a dedicated help desk team will be established to handle troubleshooting requests and general system inquiries. An IT maintenance team will oversee routine system updates and security patches, ensuring continued performance. Additionally, training coordinators will remain available to facilitate ongoing professional development, supporting staff as new features or system updates are introduced.

9. Training

The selected vendor shall be responsible for all initial training, including instructing a minimum of 5 system administrators on basic operation of the ILS. These administrators will be required to train the librarians that report to them, who will in turn train supervisors and staff on department-specific operations. Training materials shall be made available to SPL for further training as new staff members are hired into the system. SPL's training plan may be reviewed below.

Event	Deadline (from Acceptance)
System Administrators Training	Within 4 weeks
Librarians	Within 6 weeks
Supervisors	Within 10 weeks
Paraprofessional staff	Within 12 weeks

Training should be performed both virtually and on-site as the desired ILS will offer a cloud-based solution. Training will be performed in a sandbox environment (see "Testing") and will run parallel to standard library operations and procedures. While system administrators will be able to perform

complex tasks in the new environment, other staff will be trained on operations that concern only their daily professional duties.

10. Data Migration

The migration from SPL's current ILS, Horizon by SirsiDynix, to a web-based SaaS solution will be conducted in several carefully planned stages to protect data integrity and minimize service disruptions. The process will begin with data extraction and backup, during which all bibliographic, circulation, and patron records will be retrieved from Horizon. To ensure that no data is lost a comprehensive backup will be performed before migration begins. Once extracted, the data will undergo cleaning and validation, with duplicate, outdated, or corrupted records being removed. Special attention will be given to metadata integrity, ensuring compliance with MARC21, BIBFRAME, and RDA standards for seamless cataloging and discovery.

Once the dataset has been validated, records will be converted to align with the new ILS format. This step will involve standardizing cataloging fields, optimizing search functionalities, and ensuring compatibility with SPL's existing discovery platform, BiblioCore. Before full migration, a test migration will be performed in a sandbox environment, where records will be reviewed for accuracy and system functionality will be assessed. This will allow staff to identify and resolve potential issues before the final transition takes place.

The final migration will be scheduled during a low-traffic period to ensure that there is minimal disruption to library services. Once the transfer is complete, a post-migration audit will need to be conducted to confirm that all records have been adequately and accurately imported and that system features are operating as expected. Following this verification, staff training will be provided. The training will focus on data retrieval, catalog maintenance, and new system workflows.

11. System Customization

SPL is seeking a customizable system to meet its unique operational and user requirements. This section outlines the customization approach, ensuring the system is tailored to the needs of SPL's staff, patrons, and technologies. Vendors need to align with SPL's proposed solutions and provide past examples of projects that had similar scopes.

1. User Interface Customization

- Customizable search filters and catalog views for both users and staff
- Incorporating branding logos, themes, and color schemes to align with SPL's overall brand
- Accessibility compliance adjustments to support ADA standards

2. Workflow and Automation

- Custom workflow creation for circulation, acquisitions, and user interactions
- Automated notifications and alerts for overdue books, holds, and event reminders for staff and users
- Role-based access to ensure appropriate permissions for different user groups

3. Integration

- Seamless integration with SPL's existing catalog and databases
- Compatibility with third-party vendors, including e-book providers, payment gateways, and interlibrary loan services

4. Data Management & Reporting

- Customizable reports
- Search and filtering options for data analysis
- Secure data export functionality for further analysis and compliance reporting

5. Future Custom Features

- Vendor-led development of library-specific functionalities upon request
- Planning for future enhancements based on SPL's needs
- Testing and validation procedures ensure the smooth deployment of custom features

12. Testing

The vendor will provide a testing environment that may run simultaneously with SPL's legacy ILS in order to ensure a smooth transition between systems and allow time for staff training. Sandbox tests will prioritize accessibility as a major feature of the selected ILS, ensuring its compatibility with screen readers and other assistive technology. Testing will also be performed to ensure interoperability with third-party library products and efficacy of user search interface. Standard automated procedures to be performed in the testing environment including standard circulation tasks, user account retrieval, standard cataloging tasks, and generating reports will ensure proper ILS functioning upon launch and explore staff interface customization.

Initial tests will be performed by a working group composed of at least five but no more than seven system administrators from different library departments, including but not limited to reference, cataloging, public relations, and information technology. These tests are to be completed throughout the training period outlined under "Training". Following launch of the ILS, new concerns from staff should be directed to this same team and then considered as grounds for changes to be made to the system. While reconfiguration of the digital environment may be ongoing as SPL services change and evolve, the selected ILS is expected to be fully functional by launch day and should pose no major interruptions to standard library operations.

13. Go-Live Strategies

A phased approach will be used for the system launch to ensure a smooth transition while minimizing disruptions for both staff and patrons.

In the first phase, a parallel testing period will need to take place, during which the new ILS will operate alongside Horizon. This will allow for real-time comparisons of transactions and system functionality, ensuring that workflows remain consistent. Staff feedback will be collected, and any identified issues will be addressed before full deployment.

Following this, a soft launch will then be initiated. During this period, the system will be made available to staff and select users allowing time for hands-on use in a controlled setting. Self-service kiosks and online portals will be tested, ensuring that public-facing functions operate as intended. To assist patrons, on-site support stations will be set up at major branches, with staff available to answer questions and offer guidance.

The final go-live event will involve the full transition to the new ILS, at which point Horizon will be retired. Throughout this process, a help desk team will remain available to assist with troubleshooting and immediate concerns. On-site support personnel will also need to be stationed at key locations to provide direct assistance to library staff and users.

Post-implementation monitoring will continue for at least three months to evaluate system performance, user experience and overall adoption. Adjustments will be made as needed, and additional training sessions will be scheduled based on staff and patron feedback. A final assessment report will be compiled, documenting the implementation process, challenges encountered, and best practices for future system upgrades.

References

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